

The Goal of a Project

What Do Clients Actually Buy?

The Project Goal

We do "Software Engineering" as "Projects" to solve stakeholders' problems. It's easy to forget the real goal along the way.

The real goal of a project is **not making code**.

Deliver measurable value to stakeholders by solving the right problem within agreed constraints.

In short, it is **making clients happy**.

Clients and Stakeholders

Stakeholders = everyone who cares about, or is affected by, the project.

Clients are one kind of stakeholder — the ones paying for or requesting the work. Others include:

- Leaders (CEO, CTO) who fund and sponsor the work
- Managers & tech leads — your daily audience
- Product owners & sales, who shape and sell the product
- End users, who may or may not be the ones paying

In a class Project:

- Your professor and your teammates are stakeholders. -
Future employers reading your portfolio aren't stakeholders in the project itself, but they're the audience for its results.

What Stakeholders Value

Stakeholders value solved problems, delivered outcomes, and reduced risk — not code itself.

A memorable way to frame it — **UP ReST**:

- **Understanding** — truly grasping their real problem, not just the request
- **Peace of mind** — reliability they can hand a problem to, without drama
- **Reduced risk** — fewer surprises; the safe choice over the cheap one
- **Status** — helping them build credibility within their own organization
- **Time** — carrying the mental load, so they can focus elsewhere

In other words, our goal is to understand stakeholder needs, reduce risks, and deliver the software they need; simply put **make them happy.**

- The next two slides go deeper on two of these:
understanding the problem, and delivering outcomes while reducing risk.

Understand the Real Problem

Before jumping to a solution:

- Learn the true goal, not just the literal request
- Understand how the problem started, and why it matters
- Identify who's affected, and how

Deliver Outcomes, Reduce Risk

Stakeholders need confidence that the project will succeed.

- Be the reliable, safe choice, not just the cheapest one
- Use quick prototypes to reduce uncertainty early
- Reduce their mental load, so they can focus on what matters most

Build Trust Through Communication

Worst case: "Everything's fine," but no real progress; no updates; inaccurate or "white lie" reports; blaming others.

Best case: Steady, small progress; honest updates — good or bad; learning from mistakes and preventing repeats.

Recap: Software Engineers Are Professional Problem Solvers

- Solve problems by managing complexity
- Solve problems using tools and rules
- Solve problems as a team
- Earn trust by proving themselves capable problem solvers

Projects are how we demonstrate our ability to solve real-world problems and deliver real value to clients and stakeholders.